Nasir Almasri

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Research Interests

comparative politics; security studies; political violence; authoritarian institutions and democratic backsliding; courts and counterterrorism; colonial legacies; opposition movements; Middle East and North Africa.

Appointments

Wellesley College — Wellesley, MA
Mellon Fellow, Peace & Justice Studies — 2026 – Present

Boston University — Boston, MA
Postdoctoral Scholar, Society of Fellows — 2024 – 2026

Harvard Kennedy School — Cambridge, MA
Predoctoral Scholar, Middle East Initiative — 2022 – 2024

Middle East Institute — Washington, DC
Graduate Fellow — 2023 – 2024

Education

MIT — 2017 – 2024
PhD in Political Science

The University of Chicago — 2015 – 2017
MA in International Relations
Morton A. Kaplan Prize for Best MA Thesis

Southern Illinois University Edwardsville — 2011 – 2015
BS in Political Science *(Summa Cum Laude)*
BA in History *(Summa Cum Laude)*

Publications

Book Project

1. *The Colonial Origins of Opposition: State Formation, Political Competition, and the Evolution of Radicalism*

Journal Articles

1. 2026. "Colonial Legacies and the Dynamics of Opposition: How Factional Power Shapes Cycles of Moderation and Radicalization" *Perspectives on Politics*: pp. 1-23. Link
2. 2025. "Moral Shocks and (De)mobilization." *Contention*, Volume 13, Issue 1, pp. 102-137 (with Dana El Kurd and Alexei Abrahams). Link
3. 2022. "Mental Health and the PhD: Insights and Implications for Political Science." *PS: Politics and Political Science*, Volume 55, Issue 2, pp. 347-353 (with Blair Read and Clara Vandeweerdt). Link

Working Papers

1. "Rethinking the Moderate-Radical Dichotomy in Opposition Politics." *Being prepared for submission.*
2. "Where is the Madani State? The Evolution of Political Parties in the Middle East" (with Marsin Alshamary). *Being prepared for submission.*
3. "Why States Keep Fighting: Coercion and the Regeneration of Military Assets in the Iran War." *Being prepared for submission.*
4. "The Politics of Counterterrorism: Historical Legacies and Institutional Change."
5. "Mobilization without Organization" (with Dana El Kurd and Alexei Abrahams).

Book Chapters

1. 2026. "When work is personal: closeness to research and its effect on well-being," with Amirah Aly, in *Academic Chutes and Ladders* (Bloomsbury), ed. by Kerry Crawford and Leah Windsor. Link
2. 2022. "Mental health and well-being in graduate school," with Dana El Kurd, in *Strategies for Navigating Grad School*, edited by by Kevin G. Lorentz II et al (American Political Science Association). Link

Teaching

"Conflict Transformation," Wellesley College	Scheduled: Spring 2027
"People Power in the Digital Age," Wellesley College	Fall 2026
"Introduction to Comparative Politics," Boston University	Summer 2026
"People Power in Global Politics," Boston University	Spring 2025, 2026
"Introduction to International Politics," Boston University	Summer 2025, 2026
Teaching Assistant, "The Causes and Consequences of War and Peace," MIT	Spring 2020
Teaching Assistant, "Introduction to Comparative Politics," MIT	Fall 2019

Additional Training: Teaching + Learning Lab, MIT
Teaching Development Fellow, Dept. of Political Science 2023-2024
Kaufman Teaching Certificate Program Spring 2023

Research Consulting

North American Arab Council for the Social Sciences Remote
Senior Consultant | Survey Design and Analysis 2026 – Present

Program on Political Violence Chicago, IL
Research Associate 2016 - 2017

Chicago Program on Security and Threats Chicago, IL
Research Associate 2016 - 2017

Editorial Service

Journal of Global South Studies Remote
Member, Board of Editors 2026 – Present

Grants and Awards

Institute for Humane Studies at George Mason University, $2500 (2025)
Islamic Scholarship Fund, Makhraj Endowed Scholarship, $4000 (2023)
Center for International Studies, Summer Study Fellowship, $3500 (2021, 2022)
Islamic Scholarship Fund, Alassar Endowed Scholarship, $5000 (2022)
Security Studies Program Special Summer Funding, $3000 (2020)
Kenan Sahin Presidential Graduate Fellowship, MIT (2017-18)
Islamic Scholarship Fund, $3000 (2017)
Morton A. Kaplan Prize for Best MA Thesis, $1000, University of Chicago (2017)
University Full Tuition Scholarship, University of Chicago (2016-17)
Social Science Full Tuition Scholarship, University of Chicago (2015-16)
Dr. Gordon D. Bush Political Science Award, $1000, SIUE (2014-15)
Dr. Timothy P. Fischer Award in Historical Studies, $500, SIUE (2013-15)
URCA Associate Research Grant, $2400, SIUE (2014-15)
Outstanding Student Leader Award, SIUE (2013, 2014, 2015)
Chancellor's Meridian Full Tuition Scholarship, SIUE (2011-15)

Invited Talks

War and Peace in the Middle East, Massachusetts Institute of Technology (Oct. 2026)
The History of the Muslim Brotherhood, Boston College (Oct. 2024, Oct. 2025)
Foreign Intervention in the Middle East, Harvard Kennedy School (March 2025)
War and Peace in the Middle East, Harvard Kennedy School (Nov. 2025)
War and Peace in the Middle East, The Fletcher School at Tufts University (Nov. 2024)
The Rise and Fall of Revolution in the Middle East, Bowling Green State University (Oct. 2024)
Surveillance in the Muslim Community, SFU Centre for Contemporary Muslim Studies (Nov. 2020)

Workshops

Iran Workshop, Project on Middle East Political Science, Madison, WI (2026)
Political Science Research Workshop, Wellesley College (2026)
Middle East Research Workshop, Harvard University (2021-2026)
POMEPS Junior Scholars Workshop, Virtual (2020, 2026)
NDPS Conference, Brown University (2024)
Southwest Mixed-Methods Research Workshop, University of Maryland (2023)
POMEPS Junior Scholars Workshop (2020), Virtual
MIT Security Studies Working Group (2020)
University of Chicago Program on International Security Policy (2017)

Conferences

American Political Science Association (APSA): 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
Middle East Studies Association (MESA): 2023, 2026
Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies (ACRPS): 2024
Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA): 2017, 2021, 2023
International Studies Association (ISA): 2017

Peer Review

Academic Journals
The British Journal of Politics and International Relations
Party Politics
PS: Political Science & Politics
Journal of Global South Studies
Oxford Middle East Review

Grants and Awards
John Templeton Foundation
Islamic Scholarship Fund

Leadership and Service

Massachusetts Institute of Technology
Teaching Development Fellow, Political Science (2023-2024)
Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Working Group in Political Science (2020-2021)
Graduate Anti-Racist Political Science Collective (2020-2022)
Coordinator, Security Studies Working Group (2019-2020)
Chair, Graduate Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Committee (2018-2019)
Executive Member, MIT Graduate Student Council (2018-2019)

The University of Chicago
Social Science Graduate Student Advisory Council (2015-2016)

Southern Illinois University Edwardsville
Chair, Multicultural Center Council (2014-2015)
University Policy and Budget Council (2011-2012, 2014-2015)
University Quality Council (2014-2015)
Search Committee, Dean of College of Arts and Sciences (2014-2015)

Language

English (native), Arabic (heritage), Spanish (intermediate)

References

Richard Nielsen: ✉ rnielsen@mit.edu
Roger Petersen: ✉ rpeters@mit.edu
Taylor Boas: ✉ tboas@bu.edu
Jeremy Menchik: ✉ menchik@bu.edu